change her fortune one day. Thus, writes Abul Fazl, Khanim ‘treated those cutting reproaches as if she heard them not. But she [did indulge] in . . . thoughts of revenge.’ It wasn’t long before her daydreams took form. First at seven, then at fifteen, Shahrukh was the fulcrum of rebellions by Sulaiman’s and Haram’s chiefs. ‘Haram was a clever woman’, however, writes Nizamuddin, ‘she kept a sharp watch over Shah Rukh, and prevented any outbreak’.[4] The rebellions did not succeed.

But now, Haram had died and Shahrukh, though still in his teens,[5] had begun such a vigorous assault on Sulaiman’s territories that his widowed grandfather had fled to Akbar in Fatehpur.

Akbar had greeted his embittered uncle cheerfully, and, at a banquet in his honour, promised to send Husain Quli, Akbar’s governor in Punjab, to get Badakhshan back for him.

Sulaiman, old and alone, dazzled by unfamiliar customs and luxury, may have comforted himself, later that night, with visions of going back home. Sadly, it was not to be. It wasn’t ten days after Sulaiman found refuge in Fatehpur that another old Central Asian chief, Munim Khan, died in Bengal – and the former lord of Badakhshan found his small ambitions drowned in the vast turmoil of empire.

Somehow, ageing and injured, Munim Khan had managed to keep both Bengal and – equally difficult – the Mughal commanders under control. Akbar’s indulgent ataliq was in his eighties now, but more energetic than his army, it seems – all that the Mughal chiefs thought about was ‘taking their ease’, according to Abul Fazl. Still, Munim had managed to keep them chasing after the Afghans across Bengal, and – after that bloody battle in Tukaroi – negotiated a truce with the slippery Daud.

Some of Munim’s zest for conquest may have derived from the presence, in his neighbourhood, of Akbar’s disgraced accountant and sore loser at chaupar, Muzaffar Khan. It was this very Muzaffar Khan who had superseded Munim, his old patron, and replaced him as vakil of the realm. Since then, however, Muzaffar Khan had fallen foul of Akbar on several occasions. When forbidden his love for a man, Muzaffar had declared himself a dervish; for protesting those endless rounds of chaupar, he was exiled. His response to Akbar’s mansabdari ideas had been grudging at best; soon afterwards, he had spoken out of turn just before the emperor set sail